

Wired, January 2005

Groping In The Shadows

JUST LIKE THE underground news networks worked behind the scenes to throw out governments and colonial powers, an underground network of pirates is threatening to bankrupt the entertainment business the world over. Jeff Howe of *Wired* magazine goes into the hidden corridors of the Shadow Internet.

Just over a year ago, a hacker penetrated the corporate servers at Valve, the game company behind the popular

first-person shooter Half-Life. He came away with a beta version of Half-Life 2. "We heard about it," says 23-year-old Frank, a well-connected media pirate. "Everyone thought it would get bootlegged in Europe." Instead, the hacker gave the source code to Frank—it turned out that he was a friend

of a friend—so that Frank could give Half-Life 2 to the world. "I was like, 'Let's do this thing, yo!'" he says. "I put it on Anathema. After that, it was all over."

Anathema is a so-called topsite, one of 30 or so underground, highly secretive servers where nearly all of the unlicensed music, movies, and videogames available on the Internet originate. Outside of a pirate elite and the Feds who track them, few know that topsites exist. Even fewer can log in.

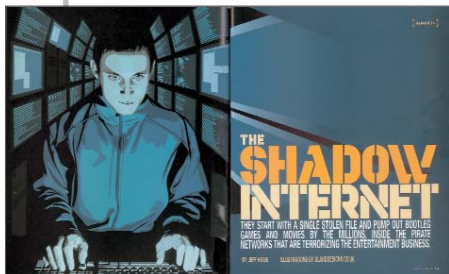
Within minutes of appearing on Anathema, Half-Life 2 spread. One file became 30 files, became 3,000 files, became 300,000 files as Valve stood helplessly by watching its big Christmas blockbuster turn into a lump of coal. The damage was irreversible—the horse was out of the barn, the county, and the state! The original Half-Life has sold more than 10 million games and expansion packs since its late 1998 release. Half-Life 2's official release finally happened in November, after almost a year of reprogramming.

When Frank (who, like all the pirates interviewed for this article, is identified by a pseudonym) posted the Half-Life 2 code to Anathema, he tapped an international network of people dedicated to propagating stolen files as widely and quickly as possible.

It's all a big game and, to hear Frank and others talk about "the scene", fantastic fun. Whoever transfers the most files to the most sites in the least amount of time wins. There are elaborate rules, with prizes in the offing and reputations at stake. Topsites like Anathema are at the apex. Once a file is posted to a topsite, it starts a rapid descent through wider and wider levels of an invisible network, multiplying exponentially along the way. At each step, more and more pirates pitch in to keep the avalanche tumbling downward. Finally, thousands, perhaps millions, of copies—all the progeny of that original file—spill into the public peer-to-peer (P2P) networks: Kazaa, LimeWire, Morpheus.

Without this duplication and distribution structure providing content, the P2P networks would run dry. (BitTorrent, a faster and more efficient type of P2P file-sharing, is an exception. But at present, there are far fewer BitTorrent users.)

To read the entire piece, go to www.snipurl.com/digit_shadow



PC World, February 2005

Those Stupid Error messages!

NO MATTER HOW computing technology improves, those stupid PC error messages keep coming, and coming, and coming. Stephen Manes of *PC World* magazine is as frustrated as you are.

Wonderful way to begin my day: A startup DOS-style message appears; the PC's screen explains that a crucial system file is missing and that I should insert the restore CD-ROM. But in the chamber of horrible housekeeping that is my office, I have no idea where the disc is.

Next step: Denial. I reboot, or try to, and get the same message. That CD has to be around somewhere. It has to. I spend a couple of hours overturning every shred of clutter in the place. Nothing.

Few days later, I try again. You know the thinking: Maybe it fixed itself somehow. And then I see something I missed before. Down in the lower-right corner of the computer manufacturer's startup screen, I see the phrase '<F10=System Recovery>'.

That's when it hits me: There is no restore disc. This is one of those machines that comes with rollback data on the hard drive alone.

Admittedly, having the restorative option on the hard drive is handy when you can't find the CD. But there's no excuse for not supplying a disc that costs, what, 10 cents? And even worse is the generic message that's not only inappropriate but simply wrong.

This kind of thing happens constantly. Error messages and what I've come to call "monologue boxes" are supposed to help you solve problems. In reality, they're riddled

with errors themselves—when you can figure out what they mean. Take my copy of Norton AntiVirus, which is supposed to update itself automatically. I've repeatedly run into situations when the updater tells me that it has aborted—and, afterward, that my virus definitions are up-to-date. Which is correct? Who knows?

TurboTax still offers a classic in the annals of dialog-box stupidity. When you exit, it asks, 'Do you want to save this file?' But what it really means is, 'Do you want to save the changes you made to this file?' If you had simply been fooling around with some what-if scenarios, the right answer might be 'No'. But if you were afraid you'd lose the file itself, you'd probably pick 'Yes'—and wipe out some of the original data. How hard is it to get a basic question like this right?

Crummy error messages have migrated from our PCs to the Web. The archetypal example: A site wants data in a certain format—say, phone numbers without parentheses or hyphens—but doesn't say so. You enter information your way, then get a message that says something like 'Incorrect Data' with no clue as to what's wrong. Bad enough that the site doesn't do out what you meant; often it will force you to reenter not just the phone number but everything else, too.

Read Stephen Manes' entire rant at www.snipurl.com/digit_error

